

AI... simply explained

You probably used AI more than ten times before breakfast: your spam filter, your phone's face unlock, the videos recommended to you. This guide explains what AI actually is, in plain English.

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WHAT YOU'LL LEARN

1. What is AI?
2. The types of AI
3. AI models
4. AI and data
5. Practical uses of AI
6. AI jargon, decoded

01

What is AI?

Artificial because it isn't human: it runs on computers. **Intelligent** because it can do four things:

1. Learn

Pick up patterns from examples and data.

2. Reason

Work through information logically.

3. Solve problems

Find answers to new questions.

4. Make decisions

Choose what to do next based on what it learned.

EXAMPLE: WANJIKU'S BAKERY

Wanjiku opened a bakery in January. Sales peaked in February (Valentine's), were quiet in March, rose in August (wedding season), and picked up again in December (holidays, weddings and graduations).

Next year she won't guess. She'll look at last year's sales and stock up before February, August and December. **That is what AI does:** it looks at past data, learns the patterns, and makes decisions.

The difference? Wanjiku has one year of sales data. AI has been exposed to enormous amounts of data, so it can spot far more patterns.

In one sentence: artificial intelligence is computer software that has been exposed to data and has learned patterns from it.

02 The types of AI

AI can be grouped in two ways: by what it can do (*functionality*) and by what it produces (*output*).

By functionality

Type	What it means	Where we are
Narrow AI	Good at one specific task: writing an email, recommending a song, translating English to Kiswahili.	This is the AI most of us use today.
General AI (AGI)	AI that can reason, think and adapt like a human across many different areas.	Not there yet, but early versions are appearing.
Super AI	AI that is more intelligent than humans.	Still theoretical: the AI of movies.

By output

Predictive AI

Good at guessing what happens next, like a weather forecast or a sales prediction.

Generative AI

Creates new things: text, images, videos and songs. Most of us use this every day.

AI models

Think of a model as a **student**. Students go to different schools (village, town, abroad) and study similar subjects with different teachers and resources. Each one learns slightly differently.

AI models are the same. ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Grok and Copilot each went through **training**, a period of learning. When you ask a model a question, it **infers** an answer from what it learned, just as you answer from what you learned in school.

When a company releases a new model, it is like that student completing a master's degree: they come back with more knowledge.

Watch out for hallucination. If someone asked you about Pythagoras' theorem today, you might half-remember it and confidently give a wrong answer. AI models do the same. That is called hallucination.

What to do: always fact-check AI answers, ask it to iterate, and compare a few variations before you rely on the output.

AI and data

Think of a **DJ**. To perform, a DJ needs three things, and so does AI:

A DJ needs...	AI needs...
Music tracks	Data: text, images and video to learn from.
A mixer	An algorithm that processes the data.
An audience	You , the user.

Both the **quantity** and the **quality** of the data matter. Because AI depends on data, watch for four issues:

- **Bias:** a DJ who only listens to gospel can't play an amapiano concert. AI trained on narrow data gives narrow, biased answers.
- **Garbage in, garbage out:** a DJ who knows three songs shouldn't headline a concert. Poor data means poor results.
- **Prompting:** "play at a gospel show" gets a generic set. "Play a gospel show for 25 to 30 year-olds" gets the right one. The more context you give AI, the better the answer.

- **Data privacy:** anything you paste in could shape what the model says to others.

Data privacy example: you ask AI to draft a thank-you email to Kevin, your best client, who buys 20 pairs of shoes a month and always pays on time. Later, someone else asks the AI to find a client who buys more than five pairs a month. Who might it point them to? Kevin.

Before you paste anything into AI, ask: could this data hurt my company or cost us a client?

05 Practical uses of AI

Grow your business

Describe what you sell and to whom. Ask for a social media content strategy, ideas for approaching clients, and pricing ideas.

Plan your health goals

Share your current and ideal weight and your work schedule. Ask for practical meal plans that fit your day.

Learn anything

Ask AI to teach you a topic step by step, such as how money market funds (MMFs) work and how to invest in them.

Term	Plain-English meaning
LLM	Large Language Model. AI trained on huge amounts of text. ChatGPT and Claude run on LLMs.
AI agent	Goes beyond a chatbot. A chatbot suggests places to stay in Mombasa. An agent also checks bookings and flight prices, advises on the best time to go, and books the flight, like an employee who does the task from start to finish.
Prompt	How you talk to AI. The more descriptive you are, the better the answer.
MCP	Model Context Protocol. Like a universal charger with a cable for your phone, earphones and laptop, it lets AI connect to many tools at once, such as your Gmail and calendar.

Want your team to use AI confidently?

Sharon Maganga runs practical, plain-English AI training for companies and teams: from AI basics to safe, productive use at work.

Book AI training at axiaanalytics.com

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